Chapters 5 and 6). By contrast, rather than assuming largely *un*problematic transactions between a singular notion of kingship and a similar, broadly conceived Islam in Central–South Asia during the early second millennium CE, the present close study of the Shansabanis takes full advantage of the available evidence to examine the identifiable impetuses behind their actuations of kingship and *specific* processes of Islamization (see Chapters 1 and 2). We focus on a slice of time, *viz.* the long twelfth century, during which the Shansabanis emerged from unknown origins into historicity.

In Sana'i's homily, the role of the blind men of Ghur would be played by the scholars from several disciplines who have undertaken analyses touching upon the Shansabanis during a little more than the last half-century. These specialists have included historians, archaeologists and art-architectural historians – among the last of whom I would count myself. As specialists of "archives" encapsulating time periods and geographical areas, we understandably embrace our disciplinary locations. These allow us to stay abreast of the continually changing methodologies afforded by each of the aforementioned fields, and the sheer technological advances that also engender new approaches.[23] In fact, the present monographic project relies on the architectural patronage of the Shansabanis throughout modern Afghanistan, Pakistan, and India as a primary source to elucidate the *architectural cultures* in which they participated, and which they shaped in turn, as explicated below. But, I believe that in the case of the Shansabanis and the northwestern reaches of South Asia (modern Afghanistan, Pakistan, India) during the twelfth century, all too rigid and exclusive disciplinary *loci* have led to misperceptions of the "elephant" as a whole.[24]

Objects and texts dating to the early second millennium CE constitute important evidentiary *corpora*, elucidating what is generally a less accessible time and place of Eurasia's past. The textual sources on eleventh- and twelfth-century Afghanistan through India, which are the primary focus for historians, have been extensively analyzed and interpreted over the last century and more. Similarly, the Shansabanis' architectural and other material traces throughout their imperial expanse have attracted the expertise of art-architectural historians (cf. esp. Chapters 2–5 and Volume II). In fact, these bodies of evidence have been juxtaposed and even deployed in tandem, thereby combining the information from more than one part of the proverbial elephant. As a result, F. B. Flood summarized thus the modern perception of the Shansabanis, which has remained more or less unchanged over the last sixty years[25]:

> Although ultimately ephemeral (and thus largely ignored by historians and art historians alike) … [the Ghurid polity's] conjoining [of] northern India with large swaths of eastern Iran and Afghanistan for the first time [*sic*] …